The Praying Mantis Style

The Five Gates.

What is it?

Praying Mantis boxing (螳螂拳 tángláng quán) is a kung fu style from northern China. The name comes from the insect: the praying mantis waits motionless, hooks its prey with its two front legs and strikes at once. The art works in exactly the same way: the hands hook, the body follows, the strike is short and sharp.

In Master Wulf's curriculum, training is divided into five gates. A gate can be understood as a level. Each gate gives you one new skill and ends with a test: you show that you have mastered that particular subject, and you move on. Everything goes from simple to complex: first the body, then the hands, then force, then the whole body, then the whole.

Three things you learn at every level:

- **Body.** Stances, stepping, breathing, force. How the body works and how it stays healthy.
- **Hands and partner.** Forms (sequences of movements) and their use against a partner.
- **Head.** What to do and what not to do. Rules that always apply.

Gate 1. Body Upright (立身 lìshēn)

Idea. Before you strike, stand. Force passes through the body only when the body is in place.

What you learn

- Eight fighting stances, called postures (桩 zhuāng): horse stance, mountain-climbing stance, swallowing stance, supporting stance, tiger stance and others. You stand, you breathe, your partner pushes, you do not move.
- Three rules that from now on apply to every movement: head up, shoulders down, knee above the toes.
- The first form: Zhilu, "the guide". A short sequence that contains all the basic movements.
- Striking the pad so that the force comes from the foot, not from the shoulder.

Test. Eight stances in a row, and in each stance the partner pushes. The whole form. You know your body: why the knee must be above the toes and why the shoulder must not rise.

Time to master. About 6 to 12 months.

Gate 2. Clear Hands (明手 míngshǒu)

Idea. The hand knows what it is doing. Contact with the partner is never broken.

What you learn

- Twelve characters for what the hand can do in contact: 黏 nián (adhere), 粘 zhān (stick), 绑 bǎng (bind), 贴 tiē (cling), 提 tí (lift), 拿 ná (seize), 封 fēng (seal), 闭 bì (close), 来 lái (come), 就 jiù (go to meet), 顺 shùn (follow), 送 sòng (send away). Each character is one thing you do with your partner's arm; the last four form one tactic: the opponent comes, you go with the movement, follow it and send it away.
- Two forms: Xiao Fanche ("small turning cart") and Meihualu ("plum blossom road").
- Partner work: the arms stay in contact the whole time, and each of you looks for the moment. No strikes to the body.
- Qínná exercises (擒拿 qínná, seizing and control): wrist and elbow. You learn how a joint locks and how to get free of it.

Test. The twelve characters against a partner, with the partner calling out the character. Two forms. Wrist and elbow techniques on both sides, slowly and safely.

Time to master. About one to one and a half years.

Gate 3. Understanding Force (懂劲 dǒngjìn)

Idea. Force is not brute strength. Force is what starts in the foot and reaches the fingers. You feel your partner's force before it arrives.

What you learn

- The bursting strike (崩捶 bēngchuí): short, sharp, it comes from tension and pulls itself back.
- Hard and soft: hard before the partner's force, soft after it. You never go against the peak moment of the opponent's force.
- Two forms: Lanjie ("block and cut off") and Bengbu ("bursting step").
- First sparring. With protective gear, body and arms; the head is not a target.
- Head and neck: you learn to escape from these holds.

Test. Two forms. Force test on the striking pad: ten strikes, the last as strong as the first. Eyes closed: the partner pushes, and you say from where and how hard. Two rounds of sparring in which you are neither stiff, slack, floating nor confused.

Time. About one and a half to two years.

Gate 4. The Whole Body as a Weapon (分身 fēnshēn)

Idea. When the hands are tied up, the elbow continues. When the elbow is tied up, the shoulder, hip or knee continues.

What you learn

- Eight short weapons: head, shoulder, elbow, side, hip, knee and others. Strikes against the pad and against a protected partner.
- Fēnshēn Bāzhǒu (分身八肘): a four-part advanced form series with an emphasis on close-range fighting methods. Its parts run from 分身八肘一段 (Fēnshēn Bāzhǒu yī duàn) to 分身八肘四段 (Fēnshēn Bāzhǒu sì duàn).
- Throws and falling. Before the throws you learn to fall: four falls, and the head never touches the mat.
- Qínná exercises: fingers and hip. A finger lock to the point of control, not of pain.
- The law. Estonia's rule of self-defence in one sentence: you may defend yourself or another person, but the means must match the threat.
- The first class you teach yourself: 15 minutes for beginners.

Test. The parts of Fēnshēn Bāzhǒu that you have learned. Throw and fall on both sides. Sparring in which a third person comes from behind and you notice them before contact. Your own class.

Time. About two years.

Gate 5. The Essence (摘要 zhāiyào)

Idea. An extract is made of everything that came before. One principle that works in every shape.

What you learn

- Zhāiyào (摘要, "the essentials"): an advanced six-part form series, that is, six forms: 摘要一段, 摘要二段, 摘要三段, 摘要四段, 摘要五段 and 摘要六段 (Zhāiyào yī, èr, sān, sì, wǔ and liù duàn).
- Weapons: short stick, sword, long staff, spear. A weapon is only an extension of the arm: force is still gathered from the foot (the hips) and directed to the striking point (the fist, the tip of the sword and so on).
- Qínná exercises: knee and leg. Knowing where the dangerous points of the body are, so as not to strike them, and so as to be able to help a casualty when someone has struck them.
- Free fighting with several partners. One solution is always allowed: run away :)
- Teaching. You give whole training classes and help with grading.

Test. The Zhāiyào forms that you have learned, and two weapon forms. Free work. A whole class that you teach yourself. You know whom you learned from, and you can say it.

Time. There is no upper limit.

The Five Gates at a Glance

No.	Name	New skill	Forms	Qínná exercises
1	Body upright	stance and root	Zhilu	your own body
2	Clear hands	contact	Xiao Fanche, Meihualu	wrist, elbow
3	Understanding force	force and timing	Lanjie, Bengbu	escapes (head, shoulder)
4	Whole body as a weapon	short weapons, throwing	Fēnshēn Bāzhǒu (four-part series)	fingers, hip
5	Essence	the whole, weapons, teaching	Zhāiyào (6 forms), weapons	knee, leg

The qínná exercises are grouped by body region in the order of the five gates. This is Master Wulf's teaching order, not the traditional division of qínná described under "Qínná in the Lineage".

How a Class Goes

1. **Warm-up and stance.** Mobility, then stances. Every class begins with stances, even in the fifth gate.
2. **Form.** The forms of your own gate, as a whole or motif by motif. A form is memory: every movement means something against a partner.
3. **Partner work.** A movement of the form against a partner, then the partner changes something and you choose your response.
4. **Pad or mat.** Strikes on the pad, falls, throws.
5. **The end.** Calm breathing. Three slow steps.

Rules That Always Apply

- **Two taps on the body mean: let go. At once. Always.**
- Head, neck, spine, strangulation, groin: these techniques are not done. They are known so that you can escape from them and so that you do not injure others.
- A joint technique is done slowly, to the point of control, not of pain. The elbow and the knee give no warning through pain: there you go only as far as feeling it.
- Sparring is done with protective gear. The head is not a target before the last gate.
- An injury is never hidden. Headache, dizziness or numbness after a hit: training ends and you tell the teacher.
- We train for health, not for fighting. Outside the training hall, the first solution is to walk away.
- Courage means standing up for another person, not proving yourself.
- Within training, first learn the transmitted version accurately and preserve its structure. Historically, Praying Mantis forms have developed differently between teachers, families and regions.

Words You Will Hear in Training

Chinese	Pronunciation	Meaning
螳螂	tángláng	praying mantis
关	guān	gate, level
桩	zhuāng	post, stance
劲	jìn	force (not brute strength)
崩	bēng	bursting
套路	tàolù	form: a set sequence of movements
段	duàn	part, section (of a form series or of qínná)
摘要	Zhāiyào	“the essentials”: advanced form series of six forms
分身八肘	Fēnshēn Bāzhǒu	advanced form series in four parts
擒拿	qínná	seizing and control
小擒拿	Xiǎo Qínná	Small Qínná: qínná sections 1–5
大擒拿	Dà Qínná	Large Qínná: qínná sections 6–10
拆	chāi	taking apart: a movement of the form against a partner
靠	kào	body pressure, with the shoulder or the hip
刚 / 柔	gāng / róu	hard / soft
虚 / 实	xū / shí	empty / full
师父	shīfu	teacher

Where the Style Comes From

The art comes from the Laiyang area of Shandong Province; Taiji Meihua Praying Mantis has a history of about three to four hundred years. Our line is the Weifang Taiji Meihua Praying Mantis. It reached Estonia in 1991, and our school is its continuation. Some forms, such as Bengbu and Lanjie, exist in both a Meihua and a Taiji version; on Master Wang Xiuyuan’s advice the Meihua material is mastered first and the Taiji material afterwards. Anyone who wants to know the lineage, the names and the sources exactly will find them in the book “The Praying Mantis Canon” (*Palvetajaritsika kaanon*; ask Meister Wulf). In training you do not need it: there you need to stand, watch and try.

Qínná in the Lineage

Qínná (擒拿) comprises techniques for seizing, releasing, controlling joints and bringing an opponent under control. In Master Wang Xiuyuan’s teaching, qínná is organized into ten training sections: Small Qínná (小擒拿, Xiǎo Qínná), sections 1–5, and Large Qínná (大擒拿, Dà Qínná), sections 6–10. Each group contains 36 techniques, making 72 in total. The five gates and the ten qínná sections are two different divisions and do not correspond one to one. The parts of the form series and the qínná sections are given as Master Wang Xiuyuan currently teaches them.

How to Start

Come to a class. Training takes place in Veskimöldre (near Laagri, Tallinn).

The first months are stances, steps and one form. It is boring exactly until the first time a partner pushes you and you do not move.

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